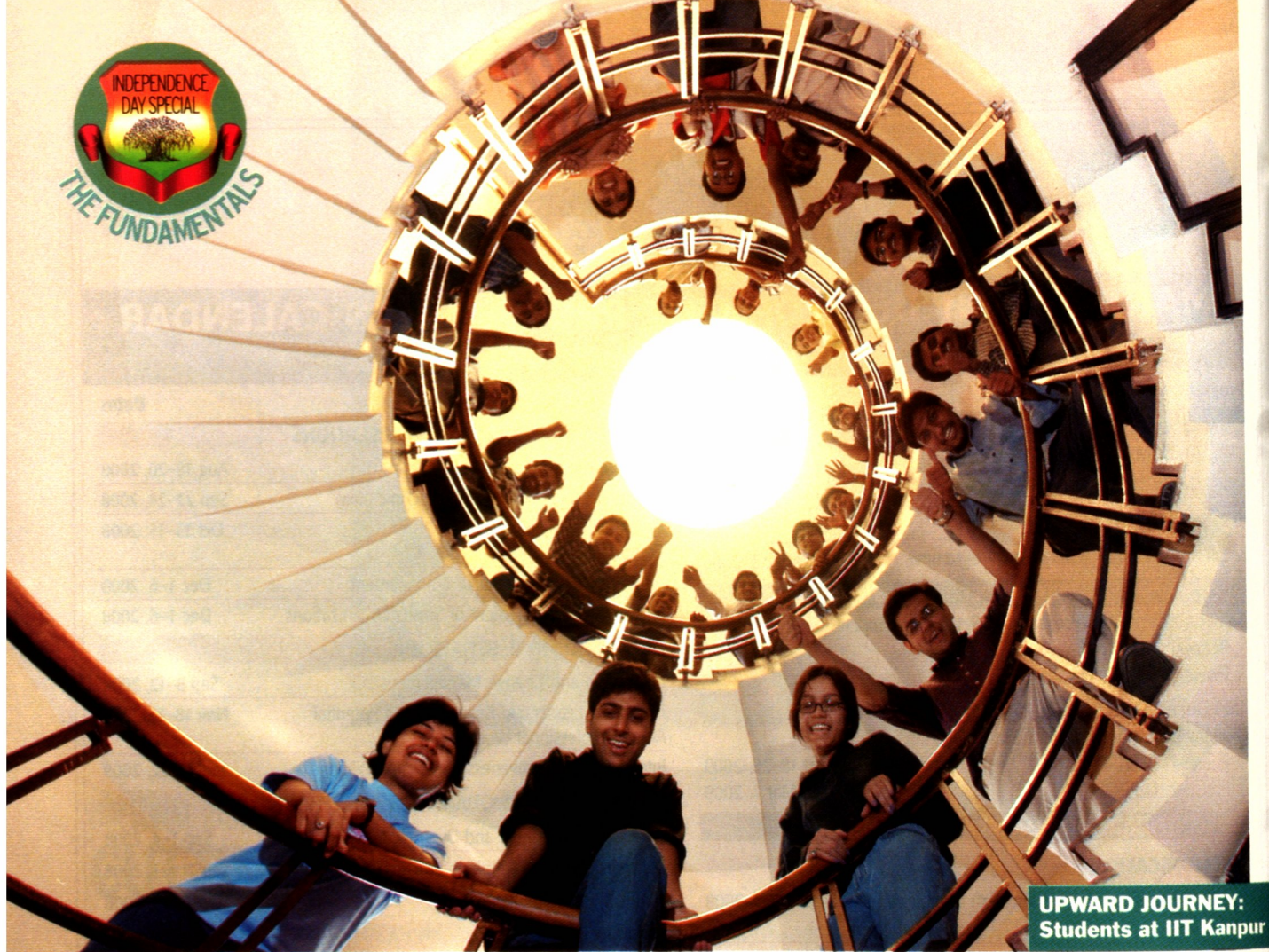




UPWARD JOURNEY:
Students at IIT Kanpur

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INDIAN INSTITUTES OF TECHNOLOGY WORLD WARRIORS

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students appear for the joint entrance examination of the IITs every year, of which only 3,500 are selected.

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The number of new IITs coming up in Bihar, Andhra Pradesh, Rajasthan, Orissa, Gujarat, Punjab, Himachal Pradesh and Madhya Pradesh.

"The IITs remind us of the importance of selflessness, honesty and ethics."

SHAILESH GANDHI, RTI ACTIVIST

At 16, when I entered Indian Institute of Technology, Bombay (IIT-B), my height was 62 inches. Like many others, I was rechristened. While they got names like Spikey, Guran, Bapu, Negi and Potty, I was renamed, Chhotu. Now at 61, many of my friends' children call me Chhotu uncle. I did not gain in stature.

However, the rise and growth of excellence in the IITs has been remarkable. One of the primary reasons for this outstanding journey is the uncompromising professionalism coupled with idealism. Even in the much maligned 'socialistic' system, the government selected exemplary people to run IITs and gave them adequate independence. Unlike many other institutes, the IITs ensured that important administrative duties were performed by the faculty. This led to a truly outstanding commitment to transparency and accountability. We could go to a faculty's house at 10 p.m. with a

problem, and expect to be helped. An unforgettable memory is landing up with 15 hungry students at Professor Jimmy Isaac's house at midnight, and being fed dinner. The students also imbibed the idealism which the faculty exuded.

In most professional colleges we hear about faculty having favourites or victimising some students; IITs rarely witness such behaviour. The malady of teachers taking tuitions is also unheard of here. The IITs are now under political pressure to increase the number of students and institutes without adequate planning and funding. The political masters in the HRD Ministry in the last decade have been 'chhotus' who have sought to control IITs to achieve political goals. If this is allowed, it would bring a decline in these institutions of national importance.

by Shailesh Gandhi

The author is an IIT-Bombay alumnus